wanted to remind his European audience was that the nations of Central Europe too are the heirs to Europe's Judaeo-Greco-Christian-Humanist culture. Obviously, the ways in which this culture was adopted were different in Eastern Europe as a whole and in the various nations within it. (There were also differences in the ways European culture expressed itself in Italy and in Britain, in Spain and in Sweden.) But that does not make Eastern Europe less European.

It is also true that in south-east Europe and 'Eastern Europe proper', the late arrival of Enlightenment ideas resulted in a slower societal development and less experience of liberal democracy, but even that does not make these countries less European, only less Western European.

For the pope then – and to many in Central Europe today – this cultural legacy, above all Christianity, was and still is the key link between the two parts of Europe. For that reason, the ongoing process of removing this shared legacy has been for some time also opening a gap between the East and the West, without almost anyone in the West paying attention or seeing it as a problem. Quite to the contrary: religious and Christian argument in particular has been again seen as an obstacle in what Canadian philosopher Charles Taylor famously christened as a 'secular age' in his seminal work with the same title.[93]

There is one other major issue complicating the already complex scene. The new challenge has been that Europe, and Western Europe in particular, began to be somewhat unsure about what actually constitutes European identity; gradually identity and values became all about various rights and liberties, notably in the intimate area, like sexual and gender identity, and reproductive rights. What was also new was that justification for these liberties, as well as for liberal democracy in general, is no longer to be looked for in Enlightenment ideas and classic liberalism, and even less so in the Roman, Greek and Judean roots of European civilisation, let alone Christian ones. Actually, the roots are not explicitly described anymore, but are believed to be found in radical individualism, as philosophically embraced by post-modern thinkers. This somewhat sudden and rather selective abandoning of references to the pillars of European civilisation has surprised and alienated Eastern Europe, who parted way with the Western half of Europe at a time (the end of World War II) when the classic liberalism of the Enlightenment began its slow decline to be replaced a